

# ZeroDrift Mk3 Scanning Terminal

The camera rides on the gimbal, boresighted with the laser. The head scans, finds the beacon by its blink, and puts the laser on it — closing the loop on its own dot. One unit, ₹6,463, every part checked.

READ BEFORE YOU LEAVE FOR THE SHOP

This list replaces the 18 September “Beacon & Tracker” PDF. That document described the Mk2 design. Buying from it will cost you money on parts you do not need, and — worse — it omits two small items without which the build physically cannot be finished.

## What changed, and why

| CHANGE                               | REASON                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | ₹      |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| <del>MG90S servos</del> — do not buy | The fine-servo stage is deleted. Mk1 stripped two servos; a hobby servo holds position by fighting its own gear train, so the tilt axis is loaded even at rest and there is no clutch between a knock and a brass gear. Its backlash (~1°, 17 mrad) is also larger than the error this rig exists to measure. | -399   |
| Diametric magnets x2 — ADD           | The old list bought AS5600 encoders but no magnets. An AS5600 reads a magnet rotating in front of it; without one it returns nothing. Boards usually ship bare, or with the wrong type.                                                                                                                       | +180   |
| 100 µF capacitors x2 — ADD           | Required across VMOT by the A4988 datasheet. Omitting them destroys both drivers on the first power-up, before anything has been tested.                                                                                                                                                                      | +20    |
| USB camera module — ADD              | The old list excluded the camera (“sourced separately”). In Mk3 the camera is part of the terminal and rides on the moving head — that is the architecture.                                                                                                                                                   | +1,400 |
| Red filter — ADD                     | Rejects most room lighting for ₹100. Best value-per-rupee item in the list.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | +100   |
| Consumables line — ADD               | Wires, M3 hardware, heat-shrink. The old list assumed these; assuming them is how a build stops at 11 p.m.                                                                                                                                                                                                    | +450   |

WHAT DID NOT CHANGE

The motors, drivers, encoders, multiplexer, brackets, power supply, acrylic, vibration injector, beacon and decoy are all the same parts at the same verified prices. If you already bought from the old list, **only the servos were wasted** (₹399), and everything else carries straight over.

## Master parts list

✓ **verified** = checked against a live Amazon.in listing. ~ **estimate** = market-range planning figure, not yet confirmed. 54% of this total is verified; say so plainly if a judge asks what the rig cost.

| ITEM                                                           | QTY | UNIT   | TOTAL PRICE              |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|-----|--------|--------------------------|
| <b>A. MOTION — THE GIMBAL</b>                                  |     |        |                          |
| NEMA17 stepper motor, 1.8°/step, 4.2 kg-cm                     | 2   | ₹749   | ₹1,498 ✓ <b>verified</b> |
| A4988 stepper driver module                                    | 2   | ₹170   | ₹340 ✓ <b>verified</b>   |
| NEMA17 L-bracket (pan + tilt)                                  | 2   | ₹127   | ₹254 ✓ <b>verified</b>   |
| 100 µF 25 V electrolytic capacitor                             | 2   | ₹10    | ₹20 ~ <b>estimate</b>    |
| <b>B. FEEDBACK — WHAT MAKES “ACCURATE” A MEASUREMENT</b>       |     |        |                          |
| AS5600 magnetic encoder module                                 | 2   | ₹249   | ₹498 ✓ <b>verified</b>   |
| Diametric magnet, 6 × 2.5 mm                                   | 2   | ₹90    | ₹180 ~ <b>estimate</b>   |
| TCA9548A I <sup>2</sup> C multiplexer                          | 1   | ₹199   | ₹199 ✓ <b>verified</b>   |
| <b>C. HEAD — CAMERA AND LASER, ONE ENCLOSURE</b>               |     |        |                          |
| USB camera module, M12 mount, 12 mm lens                       | 1   | ₹1,400 | ₹1,400 ~ <b>estimate</b> |
| Red filter — gel sheet or red acrylic offcut                   | 1   | ₹100   | ₹100 ~ <b>estimate</b>   |
| KY-008 laser module                                            | —   | —      | ₹0 reuse Mk1             |
| ABS project box, head enclosure                                | 1   | ₹115   | ₹115 ~ <b>estimate</b>   |
| <b>D. CONTROL AND POWER</b>                                    |     |        |                          |
| Arduino Nano — tracker                                         | —   | —      | ₹0 reuse Mk1             |
| Arduino Nano — beacon                                          | 1   | ₹225   | ₹225 ~ <b>estimate</b>   |
| USB-C PD / QC trigger module, 9 V or 12 V selectable           | 1   | ₹199   | ₹199 ~ <b>estimate</b>   |
| USB-B and mini-USB cables for the two Nanos                    | 2   | ₹99    | ₹198 ~ <b>estimate</b>   |
| Acrylic sheet 3 mm, 6”×6” (pack of 2)                          | 1   | ₹199   | ₹199 ✓ <b>verified</b>   |
| <b>E. DISTURBANCE INJECTOR — ROBUSTNESS SHOWN, NOT CLAIMED</b> |     |        |                          |
| Vibration motor, 3 V DC                                        | 1   | ₹20    | ₹20 ✓ <b>verified</b>    |
| Transistor + diode + resistor combo kit                        | 1   | ₹105   | ₹105 ✓ <b>verified</b>   |
| <b>F. BEACON — THE TARGET</b>                                  |     |        |                          |
| High-brightness RED LED, 10 mm, 650 nm                         | 1   | ₹22    | ₹22 ~ <b>estimate</b>    |
| 2N2222 transistor + 220 Ω + 1 kΩ                               | 1   | ₹20    | ₹20 ~ <b>estimate</b>    |
| Ping-pong ball (diffuser)                                      | 1   | ₹129   | ₹129 ✓ <b>verified</b>   |
| USB power bank (any, 5V) — beacon supply                       | —   | —      | ₹0 reuse Mk1             |
| SPST toggle switch                                             | 1   | ₹25    | ₹25 ~ <b>estimate</b>    |
| ABS project box                                                | 1   | ₹115   | ₹115 ~ <b>estimate</b>   |
| <b>G. DECOY — THE CONTROL</b>                                  |     |        |                          |
| High-brightness WHITE LED (brighter than beacon)               | 1   | ₹22    | ₹22 ~ <b>estimate</b>    |
| 68 Ω resistor                                                  | 1   | ₹5     | ₹5 ~ <b>estimate</b>     |
| 3×AA battery holder + 3 AA cells — decoy supply                | 1   | ₹90    | ₹90 ~ <b>estimate</b>    |
| Switch + scrap housing                                         | 1   | ₹35    | ₹35 ~ <b>estimate</b>    |
| <b>H. CONSUMABLES</b>                                          |     |        |                          |
| Dupont jumper wires — M-M, M-F, F-F                            | 1   | ₹150   | ₹150 ~ <b>estimate</b>   |
| M3 screws, nuts, standoffs assortment                          | 1   | ₹150   | ₹150 ~ <b>estimate</b>   |
| Heat-shrink, solder, hot-glue sticks                           | 1   | ₹150   | ₹150 ~ <b>estimate</b>   |

**GRAND TOTAL — everything above**

**₹6,463**

### IF THE CAMERA IS NOT AVAILABLE TODAY

Buy everything else and come back for it. The camera is independent of the mechanical build

### THE ONE UPGRADE WORTH SAVING FOR

A **GT2 3:1 belt reduction** (+₹1,740) takes you from 1.96 to 0.65 mrad per step, and divides the motor’s *own* error by three — which

and is not needed until Stage 6. The rest comes to **₹4,716.**

microstepping cannot do. Everything else is comfort.

## Five things to check before you pay

Each of these has stopped a build of exactly this kind. Check them in the shop, not at home.

### CHECK 1 – THE MAGNET MUST BE DIAMETRIC

Ask for a **diametrically magnetised** magnet, 6 mm × 2.5 mm. Poles across the diameter, not through the thickness. An ordinary (axial) magnet looks identical and will not work — the AS5600 will return a constant value and you will spend a day blaming your code.

**Test it in the shop:** bring a second small magnet. A diametric magnet attracts on its curved *side* edge; an axial one attracts on its flat faces.

### CHECK 2 – SINGLE-SHAFT OR DUAL-SHAFT MOTOR?

Look at the back of the NEMA17. If a short shaft protrudes from the rear, it is dual-shaft: glue the magnet to that rear shaft, sensor on a bracket behind. Clean.

If the back is flat (the ₹749 verified motor probably is), that is fine — mount the magnet on top of the rotating platform, on the axis of rotation, with the AS5600 on a short fixed arm overhanging it. **Keep that arm short and stiff:** flex in it reads as pointing error that is not really there.

Dual-shaft costs about ₹250 more per motor. Worth it if in stock, not worth hunting for.

### CHECK 3 – THE CAMERA MUST ALLOW MANUAL EXPOSURE

It must be UVC and let software pin exposure and gain. Auto-exposure hunts on every beacon blink — the blink *is* the signal, and a camera chasing it destroys the thing we detect. An M12 (S-mount) lens thread matters more than megapixels: it lets you change focal length later. Ask for 12 mm; 8 mm is an acceptable substitute, 6 mm at a push.

### CHECK 4 – LED COLOUR

The beacon LED must be **red, ~650 nm**, to match the red filter over the lens. The decoy LED must be **white and visibly brighter** — it exists to be rejected, so it has to be tempting.

### CHECK 5 – CAPACITOR VOLTAGE

100 µF rated **25 V or higher**. A 16 V part on a 12 V rail has almost no margin against the inductive kick it is there to absorb.

## Substitutions that are safe

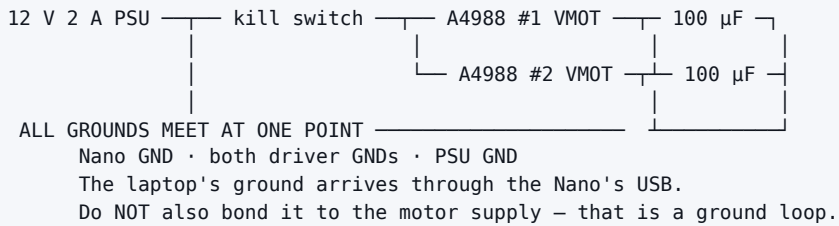
- **A4988 → DRV8825** — fine, different microstep table; set `MICROSTEPS` to match.
- **12 V 2 A → 12 V 3 A** — fine, more headroom.
- **Ping-pong ball → any white translucent dome** — fine, it is just a diffuser.
- **2×AA → 4×AA holder** — fine, and it runs the beacon even longer.

## Substitutions that are not

- **AS5600 → potentiometer or optical encoder** — no. Contactless absolute position is the point.
- **Skipping the TCA9548A** — no. Both AS5600s are hard-wired to address 0x36 and cannot share a bus.
- **NEMA17 → 28BYJ-48** — no. Geared, high backlash, far too slow.

## How it all connects

Three power domains, one ground. Getting this wrong is the most expensive mistake available in this build.



### THE TWO WAYS THESE BOARDS DIE

**1. Missing VMOT capacitor.** Fit the 100 µF across each driver's VMOT and GND *before* first power-up. Not after.

**2. Current limit never set.** Set each A4988's trimpot before attaching a motor.  $V_{ref} \approx I \times 8 \times R_{sense}$ . Start low and raise it until the motor moves reliably without getting hot. Bring a small flat screwdriver and a multimeter.

And never power a motor from the Nano's 5 V pin — it sources a few hundred milliamps; a NEMA17 wants an amp or more per phase.

### Nano → drivers & head

| PIN | TO                                       |
|-----|------------------------------------------|
| D2  | A4988 #1 STEP — pan                      |
| D3  | A4988 #1 DIR                             |
| D4  | A4988 #2 STEP — tilt                     |
| D5  | A4988 #2 DIR                             |
| D7  | Laser TTL input                          |
| D8  | Vibration base, <b>1kΩ into a 2N2222</b> |
| A4  | TCA9548A SDA                             |
| A5  | TCA9548A SCL                             |
| 5V  | Driver logic VDD, TCA9548A VCC           |

### Encoders → multiplexer

| CHANNEL   | DEVICE             |
|-----------|--------------------|
| SD0 / SC0 | AS5600 — pan axis  |
| SD1 / SC1 | AS5600 — tilt axis |

Magnet centred on the axis of rotation, **0.5–3 mm** from the chip face. Too far and it reads noise; touching and it scrapes.

### Microstepping

Tie MS1/MS2/MS3 **HIGH** for 1/16. Check your board's silkscreen — the truth table differs between vendors, and getting it wrong scales every angle you command, silently, because the motor still turns.

**Vibration motor supply — easy to get wrong.** It is rated 3 V and the 12 V rail sits right there on the same board. Run its positive lead from the Nano's own **5 V pin, through a 27Ω resistor** (from the same assortment kit), into the motor; transistor collector on its negative lead, emitter to ground, flyback diode across the motor. At 27Ω it sees close to its rated 3 V.

### CABLE MANAGEMENT — NOT A DETAIL

The camera's USB cable and the laser's wires run from the head, through the tilt axis, through the pan axis, to the base. Leave a **service loop** at each axis: enough slack for full travel with the cable never in tension. A cable that tugs at the end of travel will either pull the head off boresight or tear its connector — and both failures look exactly like a software bug.

## Build order — seven stages

Each stage ends in a check you can actually fail. **Do not pass a stage that fails its check.** Three layers of this project's software disagreed with each other for three weeks because nobody ran a check between them.

- 1 **Beacon and decoy.** No moving parts, so nothing can go mechanically wrong yet. Drill the lid, push-fit the LED, hot-glue half a sanded ping-pong ball over it as a diffuser. Wire the switch in-line on the battery + lead so it kills the whole unit. Flash `tools/rig/beacon_firmware.ino`. Decoy is just LED → 150 Ω → switch → coin cell, no firmware.

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**CHECK** • Phone slow-motion or a scope confirms  $4.00 \pm 0.05$  Hz. Do not trust the number printed on it – that is the entire reason we built a beacon instead of using a phone strobe app.

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- 2 **Camera and filter, on the bench.** Not mounted yet. Camera + lens + red filter, pointed across the room at the beacon and decoy together. Pin exposure and gain manually.

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**CHECK** • The software scores the beacon's 4 Hz blink and rejects the decoy, at your demo range, under your demo lighting. If this fails, nothing downstream can work.

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- 3 **One axis, open loop.** Pan motor, A4988, Nano. Set the current limit first. Fit the VMOT capacitor first. Flash `rig_firmware_v2.ino` and send `!`.

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**CHECK** • Self-test completes, and a commanded 45° measures 45° on a protractor. If it does not, your microstep jumpers disagree with `MICROSTEPS` in the firmware – fix the firmware, not the host.

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- 4 **Encoders.** Both AS5600s through the multiplexer, magnets 0.5–3 mm from each chip face.

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**CHECK** • `?` returns `src=E`, and after a move the encoder agrees with the commanded angle to within 0.05°. While the head is slewing you will correctly see `src=C` – that is by design, not a fault.

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- 5 **Both axes, structure, cable loom.** Bolt the motors down — do not tape them. Route the head cables with a service loop at each axis.

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**CHECK** • Full travel ( $\pm 90^\circ$  pan,  $-30^\circ/+45^\circ$  tilt) with no cable tension anywhere and no skipped steps.

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- 6 **Boresight and the dot loop.** Mount camera and laser in one enclosure, optical axes about 20 mm apart and parallel. Laser on at 7 Hz (`L7.0`).

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**CHECK** • The camera sees both the beacon and the laser's own dot, and separates them by frequency. A stable dot-to-beacon pixel vector is reported.

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- 7 **Full acquisition.** Cold start, decoy lit throughout.

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**CHECK** • Scan → identify → slew → laser lands on the beacon, repeatably. The decoy is never chased. **This is the demo** – not any single piece of it.

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## The idea worth defending

A camera and a laser cannot occupy the same point in space. So “beacon centred in the image” is *not* “laser on the beacon” — the gap between them is parallax, and it depends on range:

| SEPARATION | 0.6 M    | 1 M | 2 M | 3 M | 5 M |
|------------|----------|-----|-----|-----|-----|
| 60 mm      | 100 mrad | 60  | 30  | 20  | 12  |
| 20 mm      | 33 mrad  | 20  | 10  | 6.7 | 4.0 |

Against a ~1 mrad pointing budget, parallax is not a correction — at close range it is the whole error budget, several times over. Every approach that *models* it loses: calibrate a fixed offset and it is wrong at every range but one; estimate the range and you have added a range estimator to the error chain; measure the baseline and mount flex walks away from your number over an afternoon.

SO WE DO NOT MODEL IT – WE MEASURE IT

The beacon modulates at **4 Hz**. The laser modulates at **7 Hz**. Both appear in the same image, both are identified by frequency, and the control error is the pixel vector **from the dot to the beacon**.

Parallax, boresight misalignment, mount flex, thermal drift and range all cancel identically — because every one of them displaces the dot, and the loop is closed on the dot. The camera is the measuring instrument, not a proxy for one.

**It is the same principle as the rest of the system, applied to ourselves: brightness is not identity, modulation is.**

### What this maps onto in PS26169

| PROBLEM STATEMENT STAGE MK3 |                                                                       |
|-----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Coarse acquisition          | Gimbal scans; finds the 4 Hz beacon by modulation; slews to centre it |
| Handoff                     | Laser on; its dot enters the field of view                            |
| Fine alignment              | Closed loop on the dot-to-beacon pixel error                          |

### The accuracy you will actually get

| STAGE                                  | VALUE               |
|----------------------------------------|---------------------|
| Step size — 1.8° ÷ 16 microsteps       | 0.1125° = 1.96 mrad |
| AS5600, 12-bit, measured position      | 0.0879° = 1.53 mrad |
| Camera, 12 mm lens, 1280 px across 22° | 0.30 mrad/px        |
| Centroid, ~1/5 px on a clean spot      | ~0.06 mrad          |

**The camera is never the limiting element — the mechanism is.** Worth knowing before spending on optics: at 0.30 mrad/px against a 1.5 mrad mechanism, a better sensor buys nothing.

SAY THIS BEFORE A JUDGE ASKS IT

This rig lands at roughly **1.5-2 mrad, encoder-verified**. It will not reach the simulator’s microradian figures — those come from a physics model validated against instrumentation no student budget replicates, and the technical report already says so. The rig demonstrates the same closed-loop principle honestly. Volunteering that reads as rigour, not weakness.

### Safety

- 5 mW, Class 3R, 650 nm. Never at eyes or faces.

- The head moves under software control. Keep the laser off ( L0 ) during any scan whose sweep crosses standing people; enable it only once the head is settled on the beacon board.
- Kill switch on the 12 V motor rail, reachable without leaning into the gimbal's travel.
- Steppers warm up under stall. Never leave the rig powered and jammed.

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ZeroDrift · Team SIH26169 · ISRO · [github.com/pranshukesavmishra/SIH-2026](https://github.com/pranshukesavmishra/SIH-2026) — [docs/TERMINAL\\_MK3.md](#) is the source of truth; this PDF is its summary. Protocol in [docs/HARDWARE\\_PROTOCOL.md](#) .